SEPTEMBER 2025

FINDINGS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

After Action Review of Alerts and Evacuations for the Eaton and Palisades Fires



McChrystal Group

McChrystal Group

333 N. Fairfax St., Suite 100
Alexandria, VA 22314
mcchrystalgroup.com

Scope and Methodology

What was the scope and intent of this After-Action Review?

Scope of the Los Angeles Windstorm and Fire Event Alert and Evacuations After Action Review

Time Period: December 31, 2024 - January 23, 2025

Geographic and Event Focus: Eaton and Palisades Fire areas

Functional Areas: County-level public alert and evacuation systems and processes, decision-making, and public messaging about fire risk and protective orders

Key Organizations Assessed: Los Angeles County Fire Department, Los Angeles County Sheriff Department, Los Angeles County Office of Emergency Management

Intent of the Los Angeles Windstorm and Fire Event Alert and Evacuations After Action Review

What this AAR is:

- Comprehensive evaluation
- Learning tool
- Forward-looking analysis
- Evidence-based assessment

What this AAR is not:

- An investigation
- A critique
- A determination of legal liability

How did McChrystal Group approach execution of this After-Action Review?

OUR APPROACH

McChrystal Group after-action reviews examine the systems **interplay of people, process, and technology systems** during complex events to determine gaps in performance and actionable recommendations to improve future operations.

Our Data Inputs



150,000 +

EMPIRICAL DATA POINTS ANALYZED



147

COUNTY FIRST RESPONDERS INTERVIEWED



180

RESIDENTS PARTICIPATED IN 6 COMMUNITY LISTENING SESSIONS



1,020

COMMUNITY MEMBERS COMPLETED A SURVEY

Situational Data: *Information on wind and fire events prompting evacuations*

Response Data: *Information representing the County's alerting and evacuation response to the windstorm and fire events*

Community Impact Data: *Information on the public's experiences with the County's alerting and evacuation efforts*

RESPONSE CONTEXT:

The Eaton and Palisades Fires

Timeline of LA County Fires in January 2025

Six fires ignited between January 7 and January 9, and an additional fire on January 22.

Extreme hurricane-force winds hindered firefighting efforts and caused power outages, impacting connectivity and situational awareness.

The Eaton and Palisades Fires were the most catastrophic, burning approximately 37,000 acres over the course of 24 days, resulting in 31 fatalities and the destruction of more than 16,000 structures.

PALISADES FIRE

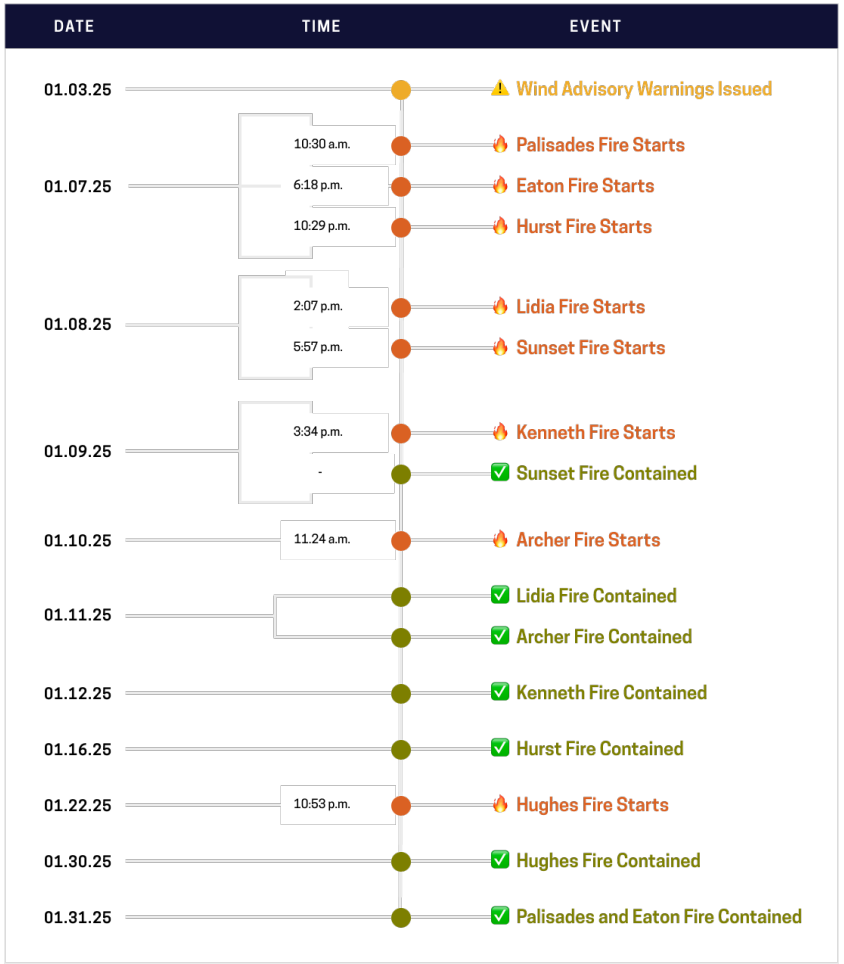
Burned **23,448 acres**
Destroyed **6,837 structures**
Damaged an additional **1,017 structures**

51 evacuation notifications issued:
- **32 evacuation warnings**
- **19 evacuation orders**

EATON FIRE

Burned **14,021 acres**
Destroyed **9,414 structures**
Damaged **1,074 additional structures**

158 evacuation notifications issued:
- **58 evacuation warnings**
- **100 evacuation orders**





Overview of Findings and Recommendations

What did McChrystal Group find in its review of alerting and evacuation efforts?

Primary finding: **There was no single point of failure in LA County's alerting and evacuation response**, but rather a series of weaknesses that impacted overall response effectiveness. Gaps in decision authority and process clarity combined with resource constraints drove alerting and evacuation challenges during the January 2025 wildfires.

Five Critical Focus Areas



Conflicting Policies Create Confusion in Evacuation Decision-Making



1. Policies, Protocols, Standard Operating Procedures, and Authority

(Report page 67)

FINDINGS

Policies and protocols are **unclear and contradictory** regarding decision-making authorities for evacuation warnings and orders

OEM operates with **critical structural and resource deficiencies** hindering LA County's emergency management capabilities

Conflicting Policies Create Confusion in Evacuation Decision-Making



1. **Policies, Protocols, Standard Operating Procedures, and Authority**

   (Report page 67)

RECOMMENDATIONS

Deconflict
key departmental policies, procedures, and processes

Update
County Code and related policies discussing departmental interoperability and authorities

Formalize
all aspects of the evacuation process

Restructure
Office of Emergency Management organizational framework

Training Gaps Leave Agencies Unprepared for Multi-Fire Response



2. Training & Planning Coordination

(Report page 71)

FINDINGS

Standardized collaboration and preparedness training is needed across County departments

Enhance Los Angeles Sheriff Department training on fire and evacuation operations

Training Gaps Leave Agencies Unprepared for Multi-Fire Response



2. Training & Planning Coordination

(Report page 71)

RECOMMENDATIONS

Standardized
collaboration and preparedness training across all County departments and partners

Enhance
wildfire- and evacuation-specific training and planning for all responders

Resource Shortages Strain Multi-Agency Coordination



3. Resource Management

(Report page 74)

FINDINGS

Shortages of Law Enforcement Personnel due to 900+ vacancies

OEM understaffed for area of responsibility with 37 Full Time Employees and in need of improved trainings and formalization of the Agency Representative Program

Resource Shortages Strain Multi-Agency Coordination



3. Resource Management

(Report page 74)

RECOMMENDATIONS

Coordinate
additional planning within LASD to formally identify surge resources and strategies

Formalize
staffing protocols, training, equipment needs, and the field A-Rep and alerting programs within OEM

Increase
OEM staffing to a more robust level comparable with other large U.S. city and county emergency management organizations

Outdated Technology Isolates County Departments in Information Silos



4. Situational Awareness & Interoperability

(Report page 80)

FINDINGS

Lacking situational awareness and interoperability across departments

Inconsistent access, standardization, and integration of technology and tools across Unified Command partners

Outdated Technology Isolates County Departments in Information Silos



4. Situational Awareness & Interoperability

(Report page 80)

RECOMMENDATIONS

Align
situational awareness and interoperability across County departments and agencies

Update
obsolete systems and integrate technology to enable a common operational picture

Assess
validate and test consistent implementation, training, and use of updated tools and systems

Fragmented Messaging Leaves Public Without Clear Guidance



5. Community Engagement & Public Information

(Report page 85)

FINDINGS

Delayed establishment of a Joint Information Center (JIC)

Fragmented public messaging across multiple County departments and jurisdictions

Significant gaps in public understanding of evacuation zones, alerts and evacuation protocols

Fragmented Messaging Leaves Public Without Clear Guidance



5. Community Engagement & Public Information

(Report page 85)

RECOMMENDATIONS

Establish
a consistent and formalized JIC activation protocol

Develop
a robust and consistent emergency preparedness public education campaign across the County

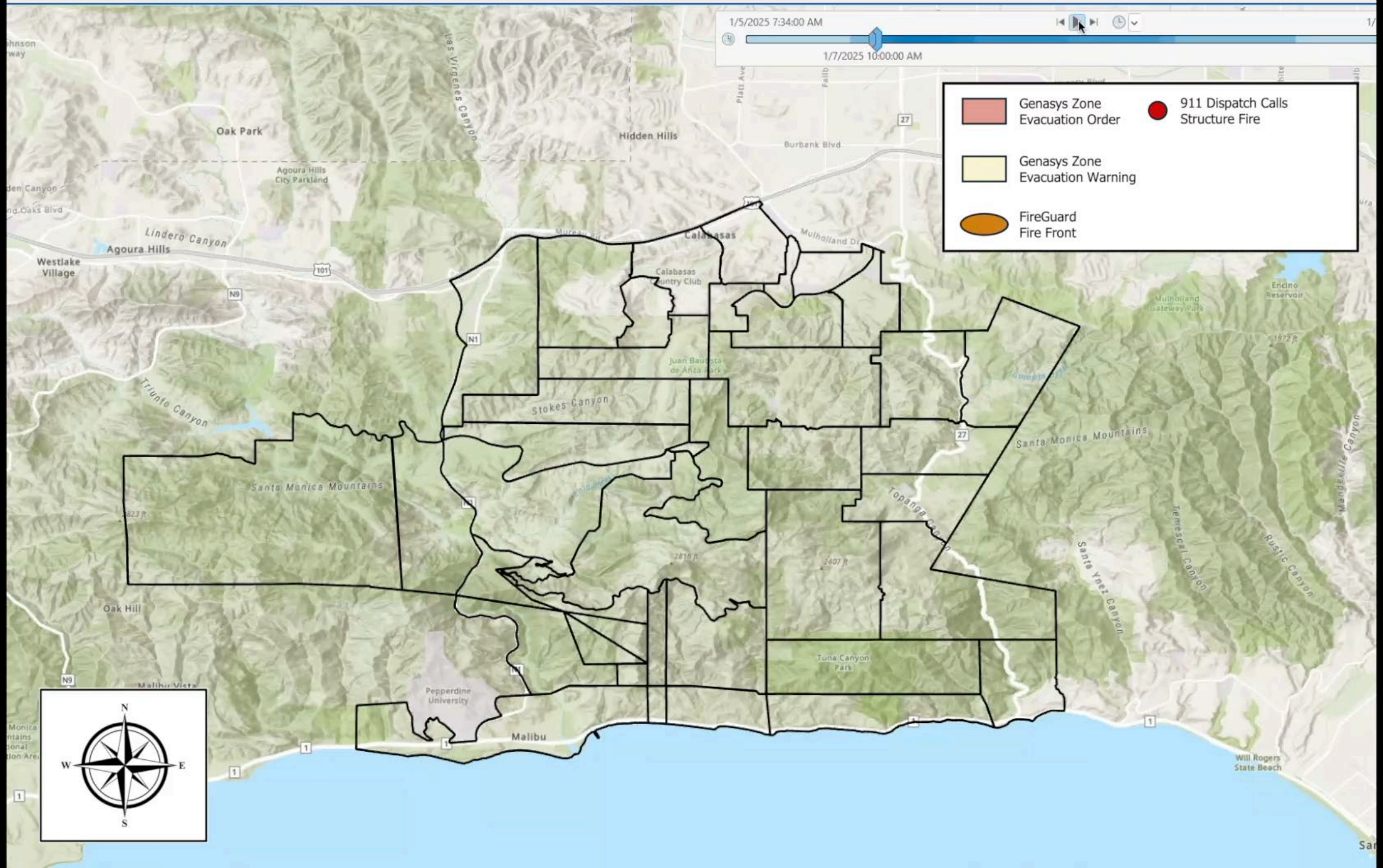
Introduce
programming to foster a sense of responsibility for personal preparedness

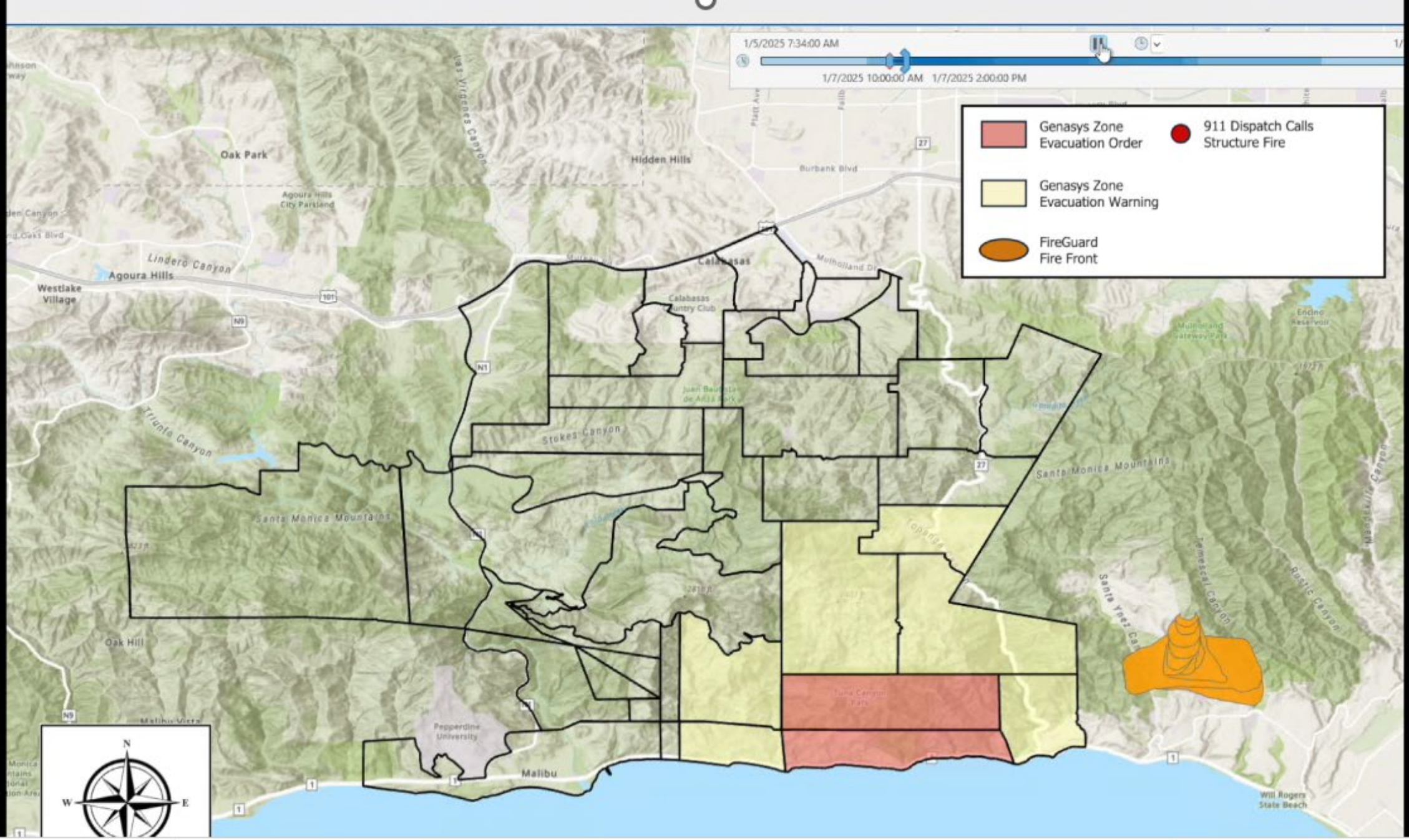
FINDINGS IN CONTEXT:

Visualizing the Alerting and Evacuation Response

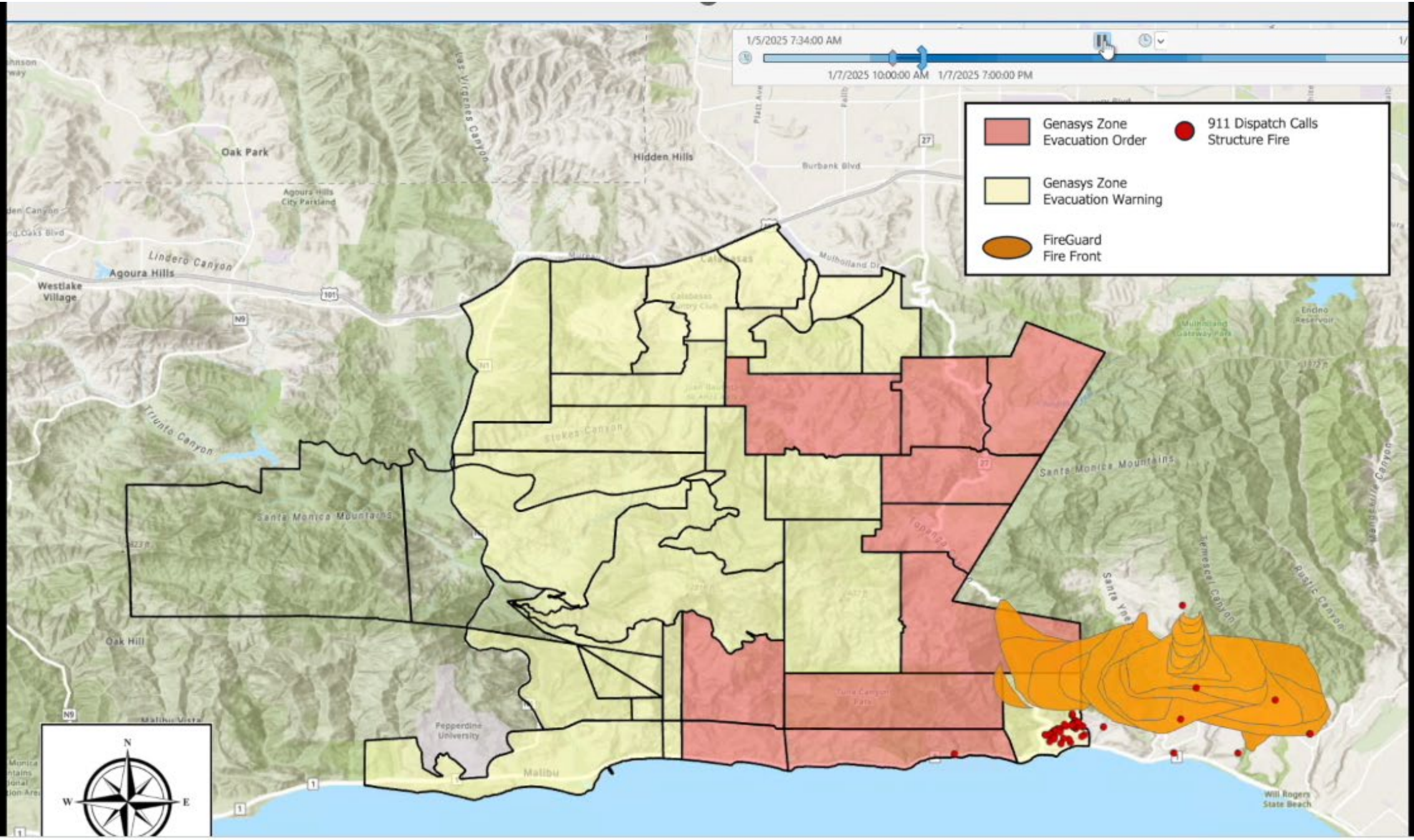
FINDINGS IN CONTEXT:

Palisades Fire

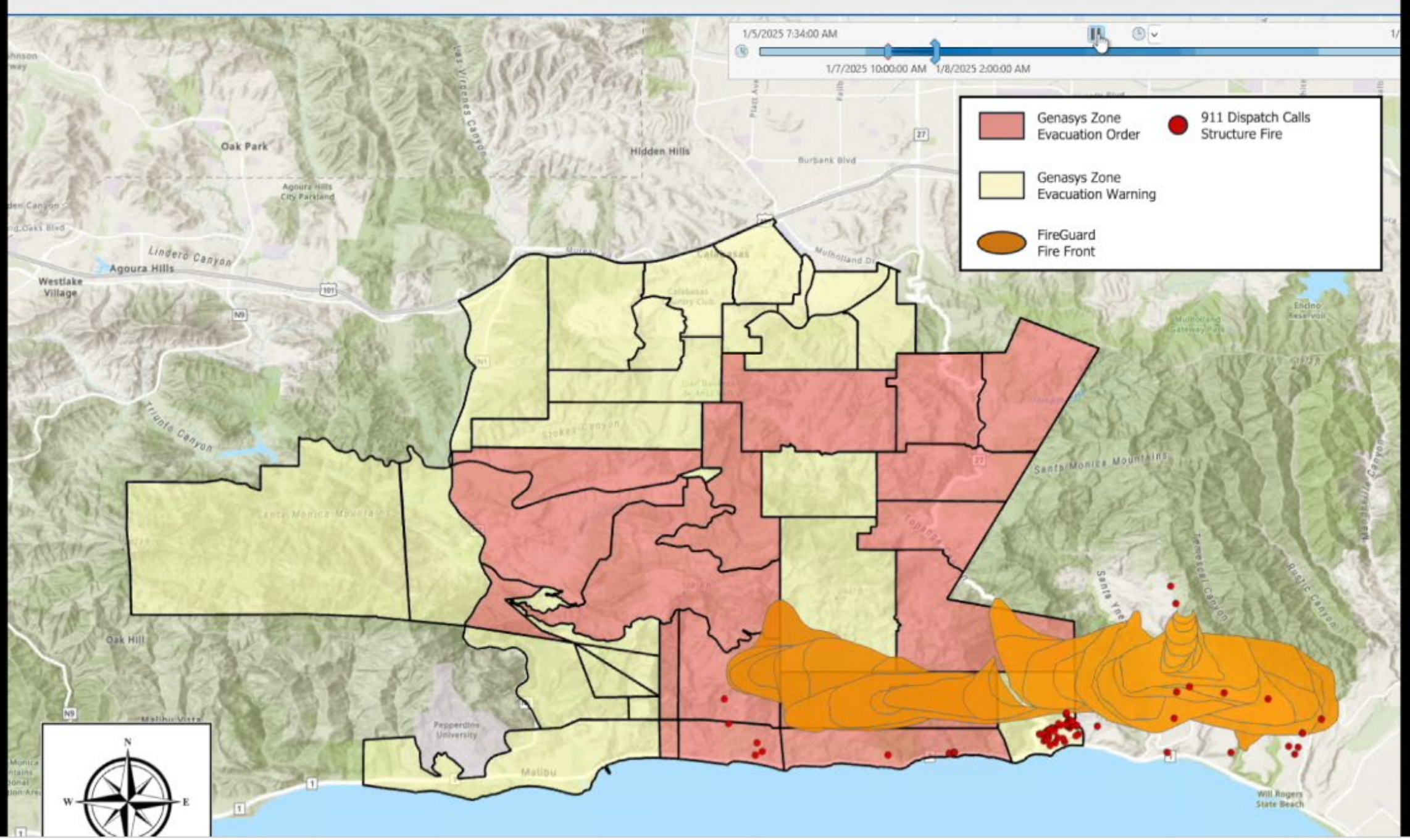

1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 10:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Order
911 Dispatch Calls
Structure Fire
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Warning
FireGuard
Fire Front
Oak Park
Hidden Hills
Agoura Hills
City Parkland
Lindero Canyon
Agoura Hills
Westlake
Village
Calabasas
Calabasas
Country Club
Mulholland Dr
Encino
Reservoir
Mulholland
Gateway Park
Stokes Canyon
Triunfo Canyon
Santa Monica Mountains
Santa Monica Mountains
Topanga
Oak Hill
Malibu Vista
Pepperdine
University
Malibu
Tuna Canyon
Park
Santa Ynez Canyon
Temescal Canyon
Rustic Canyon
Mandeville Canyon
Will Rogers
State Beach
Burbank Blvd
Las Virgenes Canyon
N
S
E
W


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 10:00:00 AM
1/7/2025 2:00:00 PM
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Order
911 Dispatch Calls
Structure Fire
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Warning
FireGuard
Fire Front
Oak Park
Hidden Hills
Agoura Hills
Westlake
Village
Calabasas
Malibu
Oak Hill
Pepperdine
University
Will Rogers
State Beach
Stokes Canyon
Triunfo Canyon
Lindero Canyon
Santa Monica Mountains
N
W
E

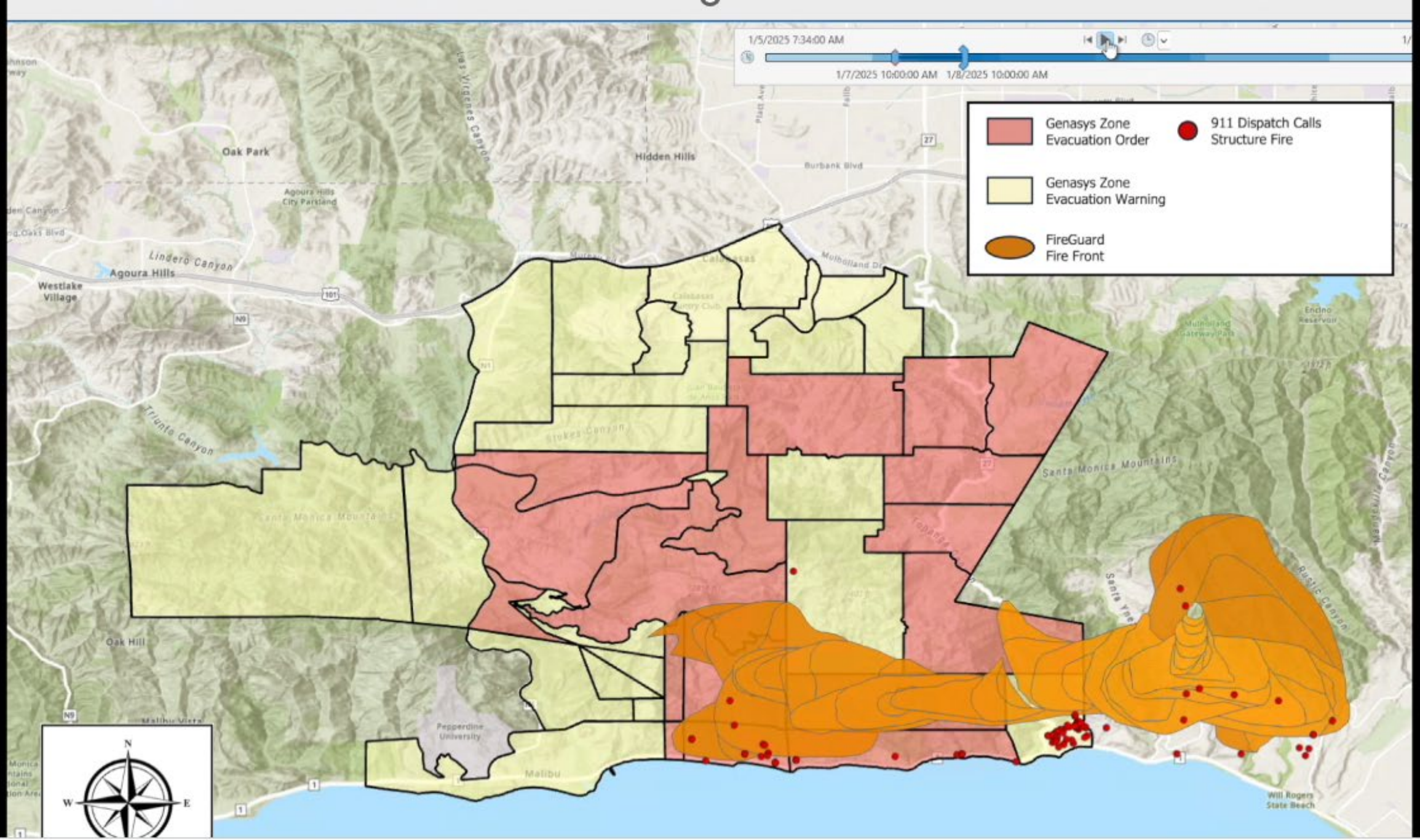
00:05.74


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 10:00:00 AM
1/7/2025 7:00:00 PM
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Order
911 Dispatch Calls
Structure Fire
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Warning
FireGuard
Fire Front
Oak Park
Hidden Hills
Agoura Hills
Westlake
Village
Lindero Canyon
Triunfo Canyon
Stokes Canyon
Santa Monica Mountains
Oak Hill
Pepperdine
University
Malibu
Burbank Blvd
Mulholland Dr
Encino
Reservoir
Tenmescal Canyon
Rustic Canyon
Will Rogers
State Beach
N
W
E

00:13.10


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 10:00:00 AM
1/8/2025 2:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Order
911 Dispatch Calls
Structure Fire
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Warning
FireGuard
Fire Front
Oak Park
Hidden Hills
Agoura Hills
Westlake
Village
Lindero Canyon
Triunfo Canyon
Stokes Canyon
Oak Hill
Pepperdine
University
Malibu
Santa Monica Mountains
Will Rogers
State Beach
N
W
E

00:23.61

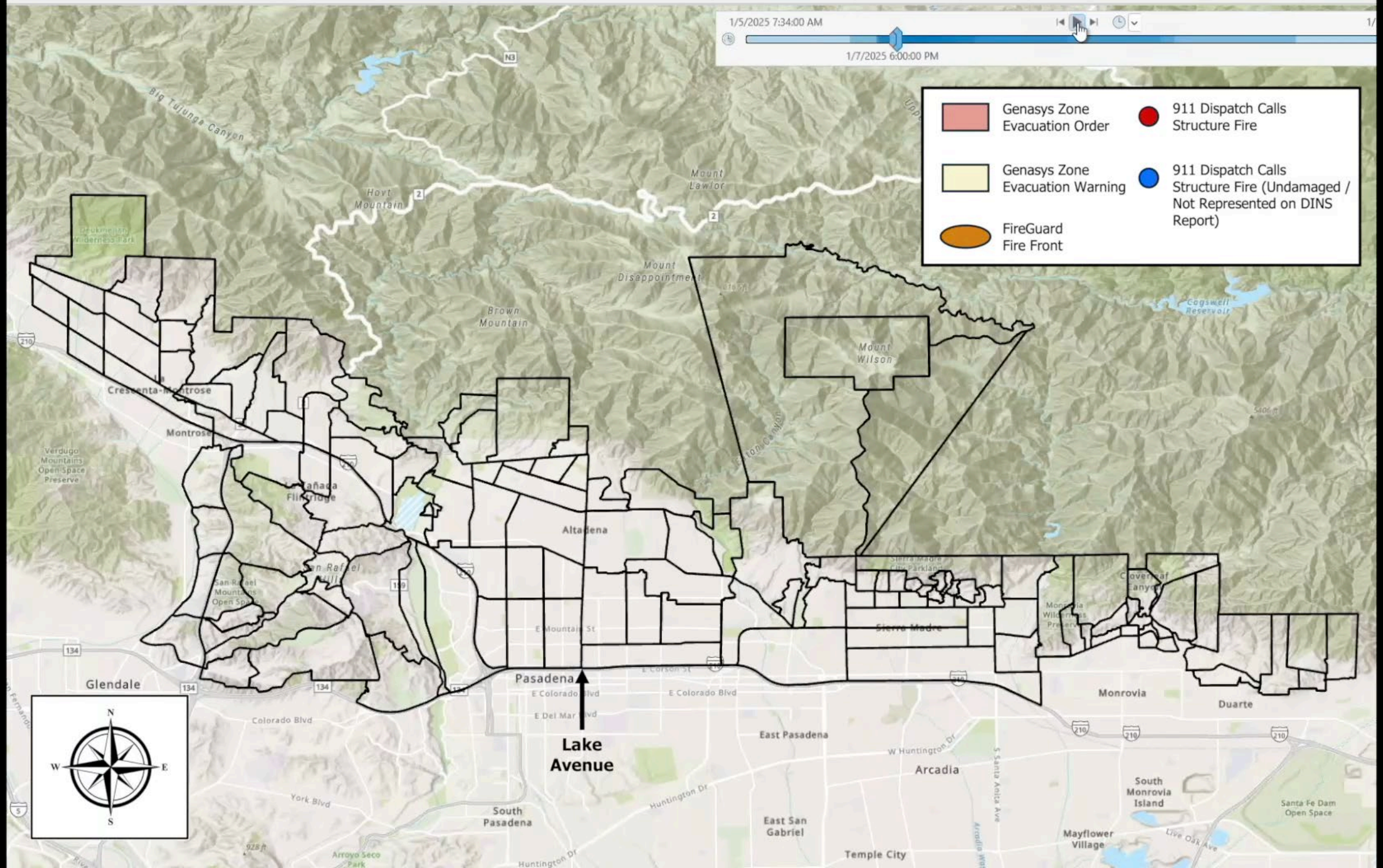

1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 10:00:00 AM
1/8/2025 10:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Order
911 Dispatch Calls
Structure Fire
Genasys Zone
Evacuation Warning
FireGuard
Fire Front
Oak Park
Hidden Hills
Agoura Hills
Westlake
Village
Lindero Canyon
Triunfo Canyon
Stokes Canyon
Oak Hill
Pepperdine
University
Malibu
Santa Monica Mountains
Will Rogers
State Beach
N
W
E

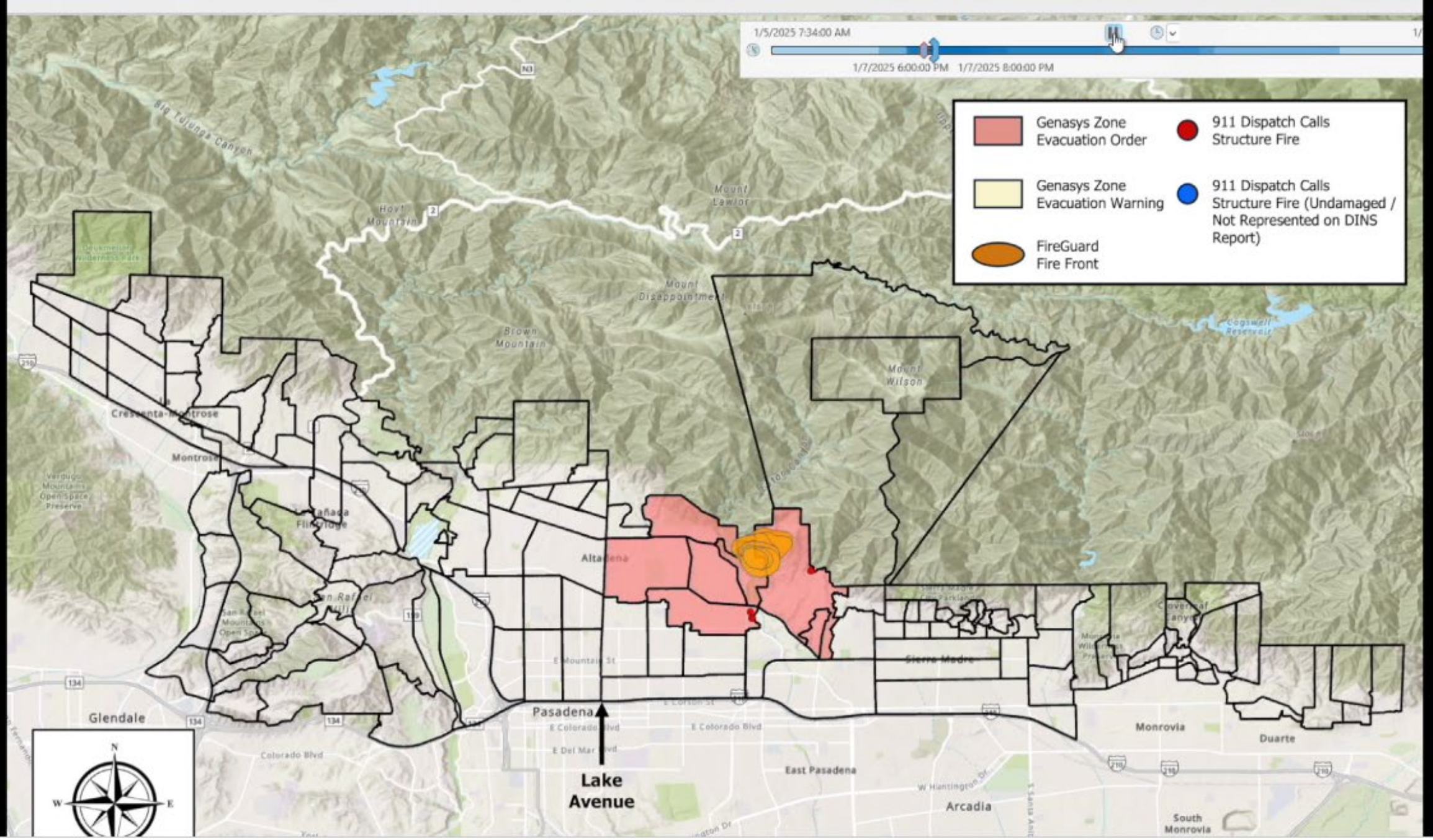
00:36.43



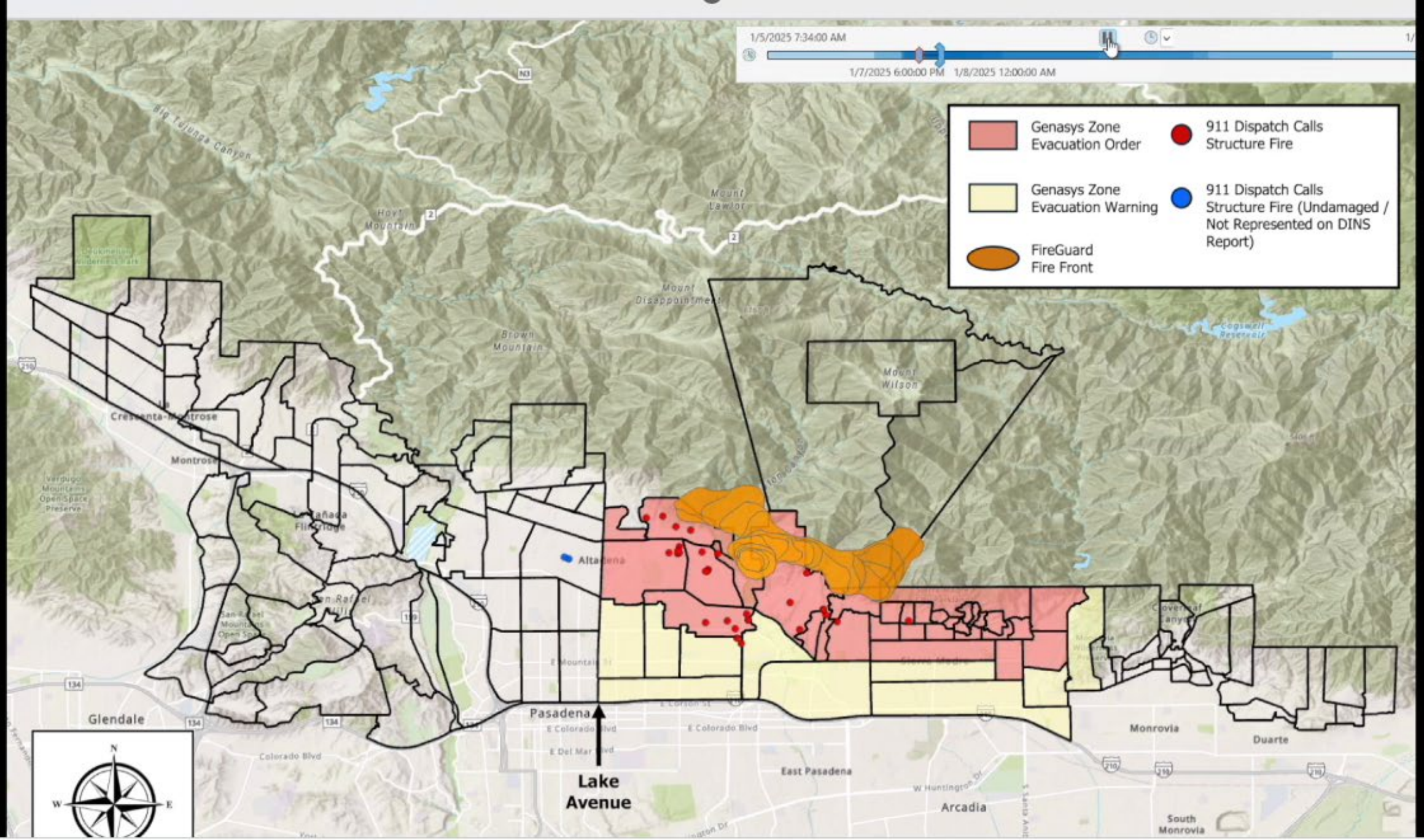
FINDINGS IN CONTEXT:

Eaton Fire

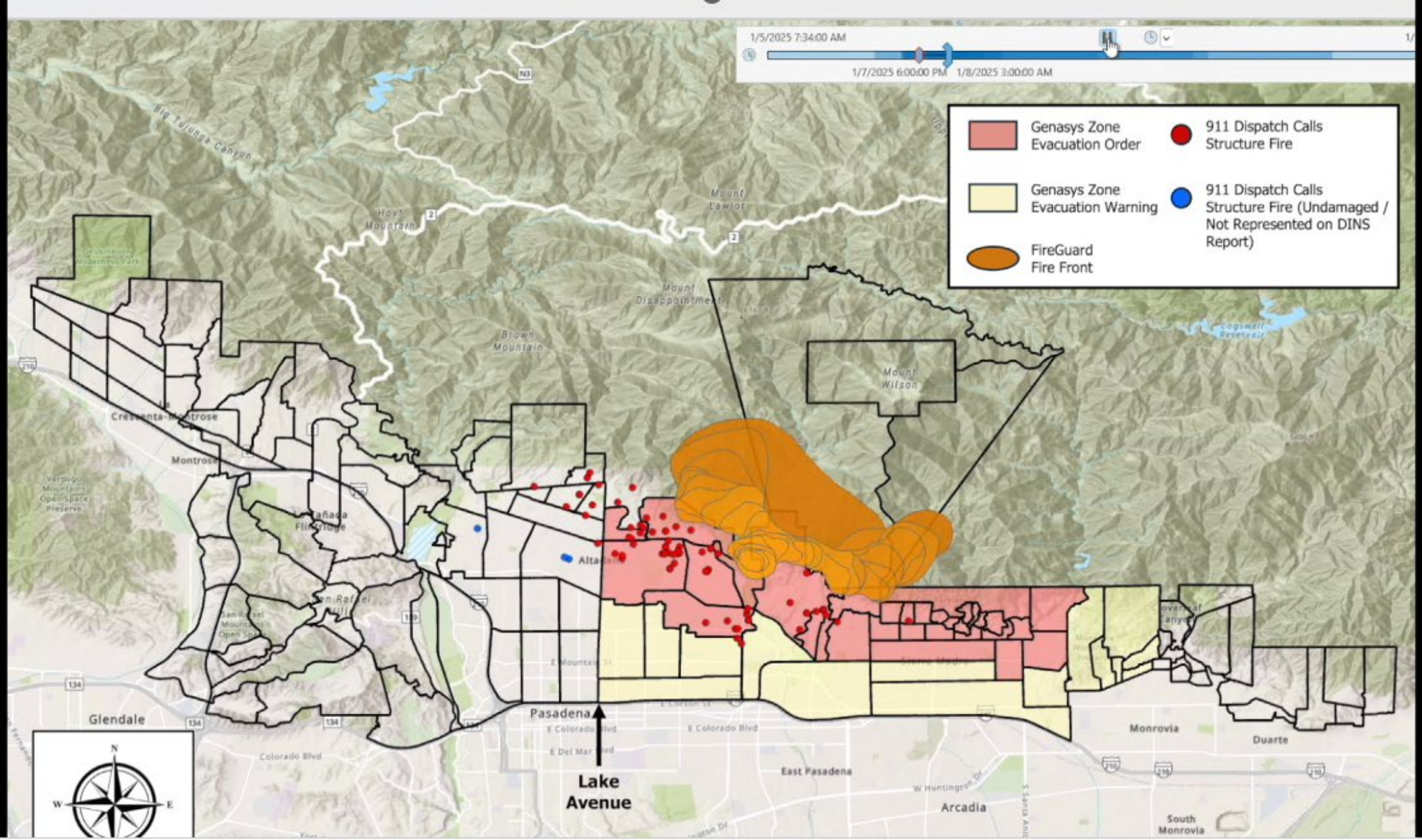

1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 6:00:00 PM
Genasys Zone Evacuation Order
Genasys Zone Evacuation Warning
FireGuard Fire Front
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire (Undamaged / Not Represented on DINS Report)
Big Tujunga Canyon
Hoyt Mountain
Mount Lawlor
Mount Disappointment
Brown Mountain
Mount Wilson
Cogswell Reservoir
Crescenta-Montrose
Montrose
Verdugo Mountains Open Space Preserve
La Cañada Flintridge
Altadena
San Rafael Mountains Open Space
Sierra Madre
Glendale
Pasadena
E Colorado Blvd
E Del Mar Blvd
Colorado Blvd
Lake Avenue
East Pasadena
Arcadia
Monrovia
Duarte
South Pasadena
East San Gabriel
Temple City
South Monrovia Island
Mayflower Village
Santa Fe Dam Open Space
York Blvd
Huntington Dr
W Huntington Dr
N
S
E
W


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 6:00:00 PM
1/7/2025 8:00:00 PM
Genasys Zone Evacuation Order
Genasys Zone Evacuation Warning
FireGuard Fire Front
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire (Undamaged / Not Represented on DINS Report)
Big Tujunga Canyon
Hoyt Mountain
Mount Lawlor
Mount Disappointment
Brown Mountain
Mount Wilson
Cogswell Reservoir
La Crescenta-Montrose
Montrose
Verdugo Mountains Open Space Preserve
Altadena
Pasadena
Glendale
Colorado Blvd
E Mountain St
E Del Mar Blvd
East Pasadena
Arcadia
Sierra Madre
Monrovia
Duarte
South Monrovia
Lake Avenue
N
W
E

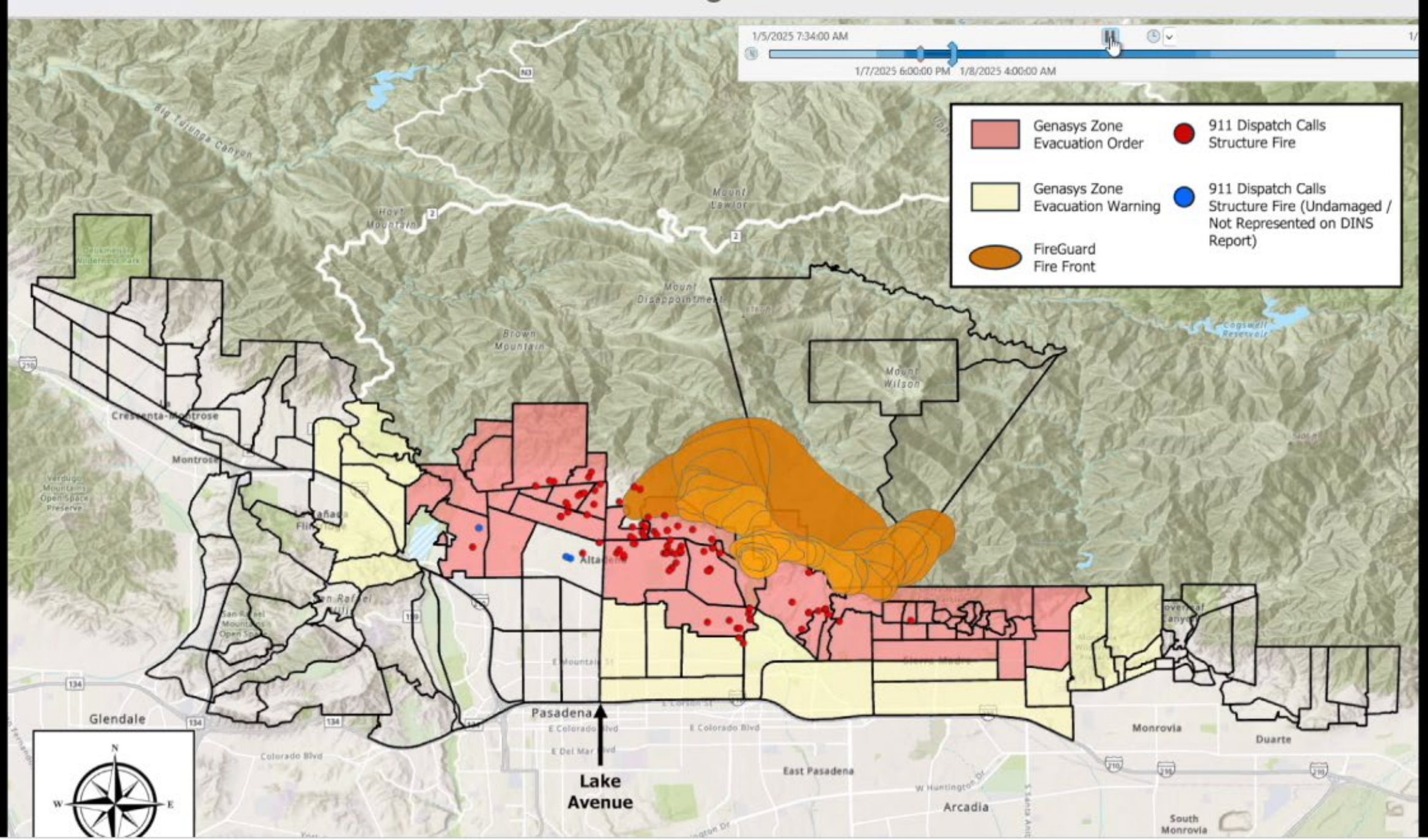
00:04.57


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 6:00:00 PM
1/8/2025 12:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone Evacuation Order
Genasys Zone Evacuation Warning
FireGuard Fire Front
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire (Undamaged / Not Represented on DINS Report)
Big Tujunga Canyon
Hoyt Mountain
Mount Lawlor
Mount Disappointment
Brown Mountain
Mount Wilson
Cogswell Reservoir
Crescenta-Montrose
Montrose
Verdugo Mountains Open Space Preserve
Altadena
San Rafael Hills
Glendale
Pasadena
E Colorado Blvd
E Del Mar Blvd
Colorado Blvd
Lake Avenue
East Pasadena
Arcadia
Monrovia
Duarte
South Monrovia
N
W
E

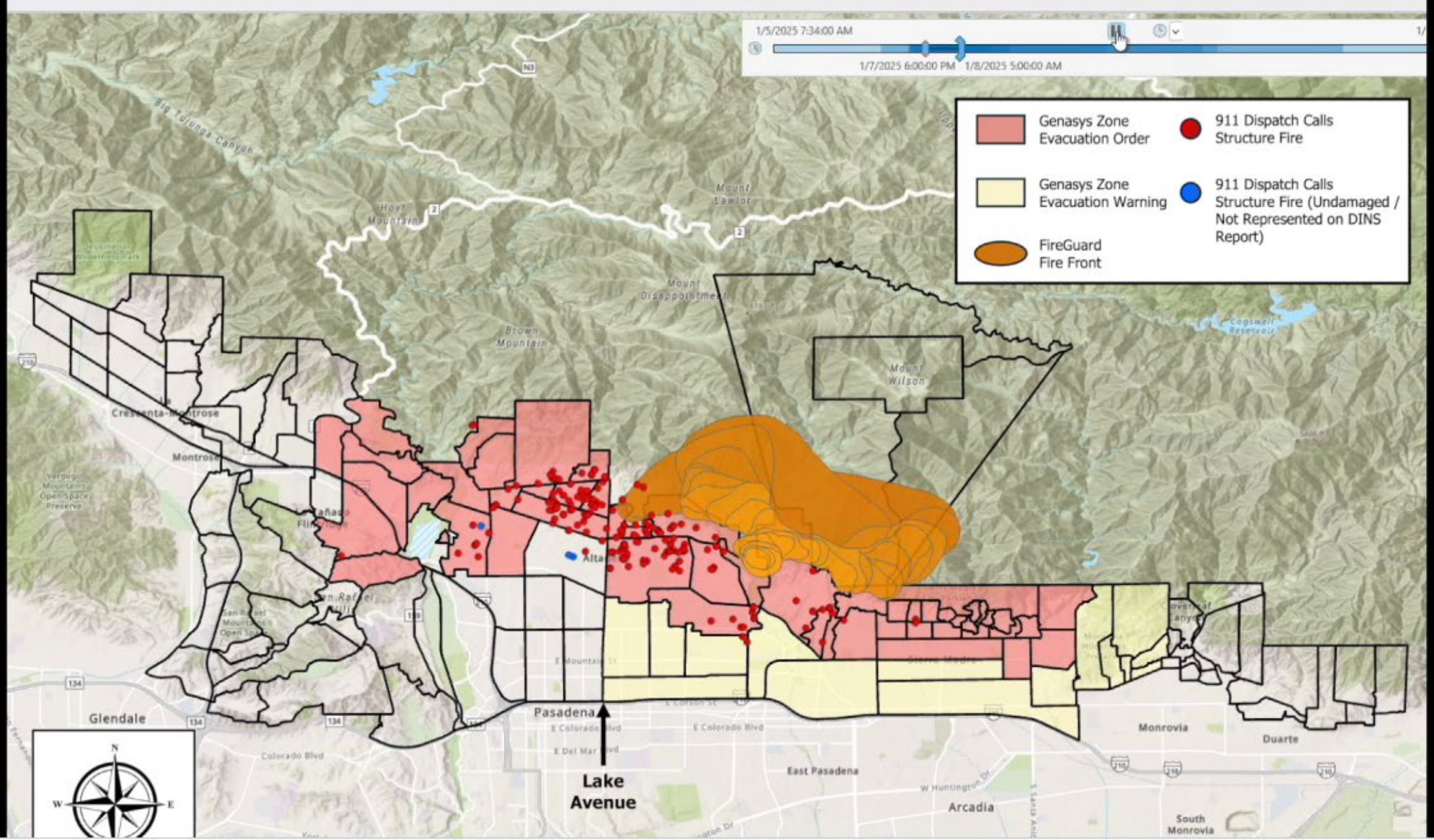
00:13.48


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 6:00:00 PM
1/8/2025 3:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone Evacuation Order
Genasys Zone Evacuation Warning
FireGuard Fire Front
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire (Undamaged / Not Represented on DINS Report)
Big Tujunga Canyon
Mount Lawlor
Hoyt Mountain
Mount Disappointment
Brown Mountain
Mount Wilson
Cogswell Reservoir
La Crescenta-Montrose
Montrose
Verdugo Mountains Open Space Preserve
Altadena
Glendale
Pasadena
Lake Avenue
East Pasadena
Arcadia
Monrovia
Duarte
South Monrovia
Colorado Blvd
E Colorado Blvd
E Del Mar Blvd
W Huntington Dr
N
W
E

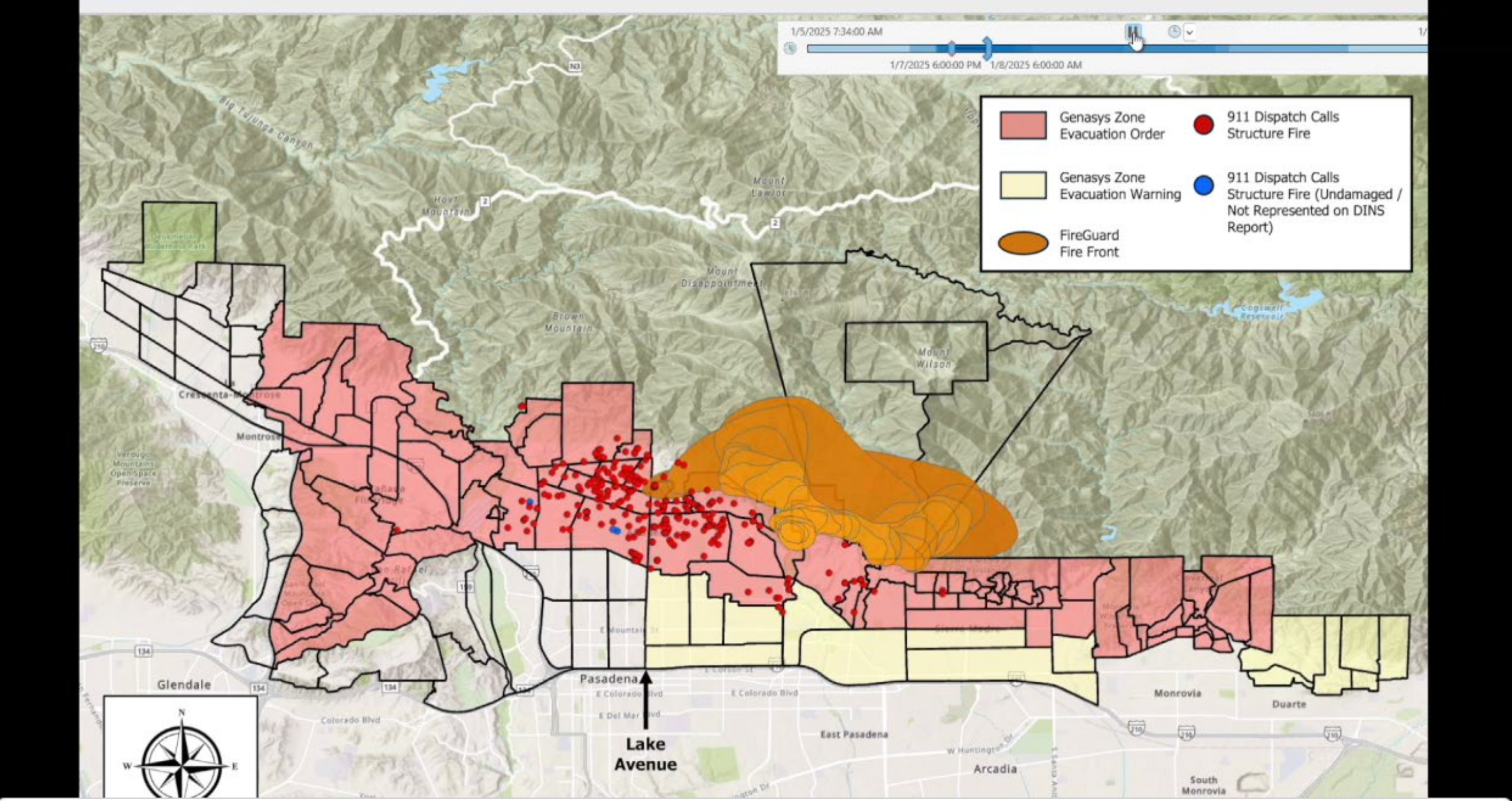
00:20.70


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 6:00:00 PM
1/8/2025 4:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone Evacuation Order
Genasys Zone Evacuation Warning
FireGuard Fire Front
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire (Undamaged / Not Represented on DINS Report)
Big Tujunga Canyon
Hoyt Mountain
Mount Lowe
Mount Disappointment
Brown Mountain
Mount Wilson
Cogswell Reservoir
Crescenta-Montrose
Montrose
Glendale
Pasadena
Altadena
Lake Avenue
East Pasadena
Arcadia
Monrovia
Duarte
South Monrovia
Colorado Blvd
E Colorado Blvd
N
W
E

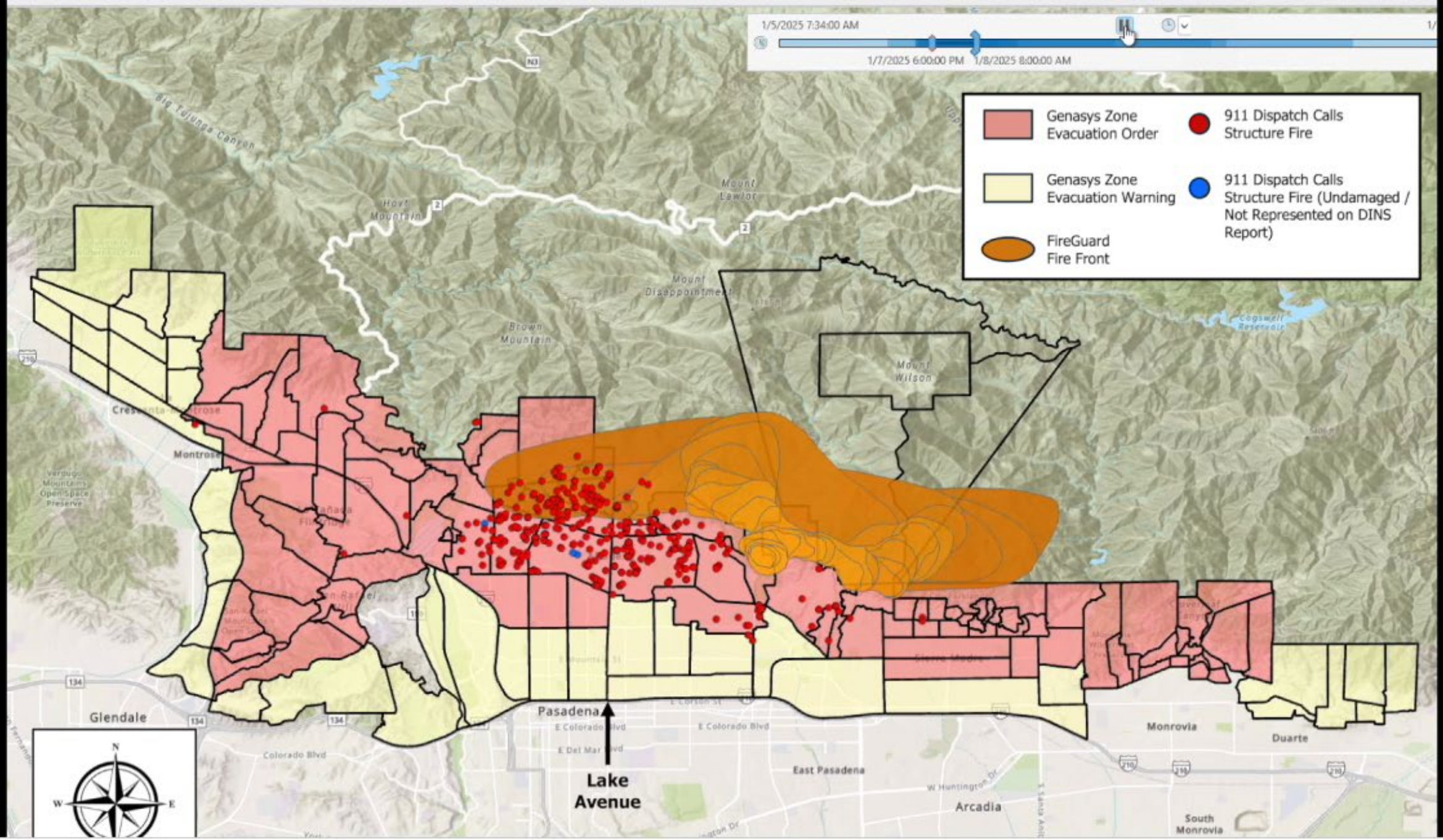
00:22.59


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 6:00:00 PM
1/8/2025 5:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone Evacuation Order
Genasys Zone Evacuation Warning
FireGuard Fire Front
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire (Undamaged / Not Represented on DINS Report)
Big Tujunga Canyon
Mount Lawlor
Hoyt Mountain
Mount Disappointment
Brown Mountain
Mount Wilson
Cogswell Reservoir
Crescenta-Montrose
Montrose
Glendale
Pasadena
Lake Avenue
East Pasadena
Arcadia
Monrovia
Duarte
South Monrovia
N
W
E

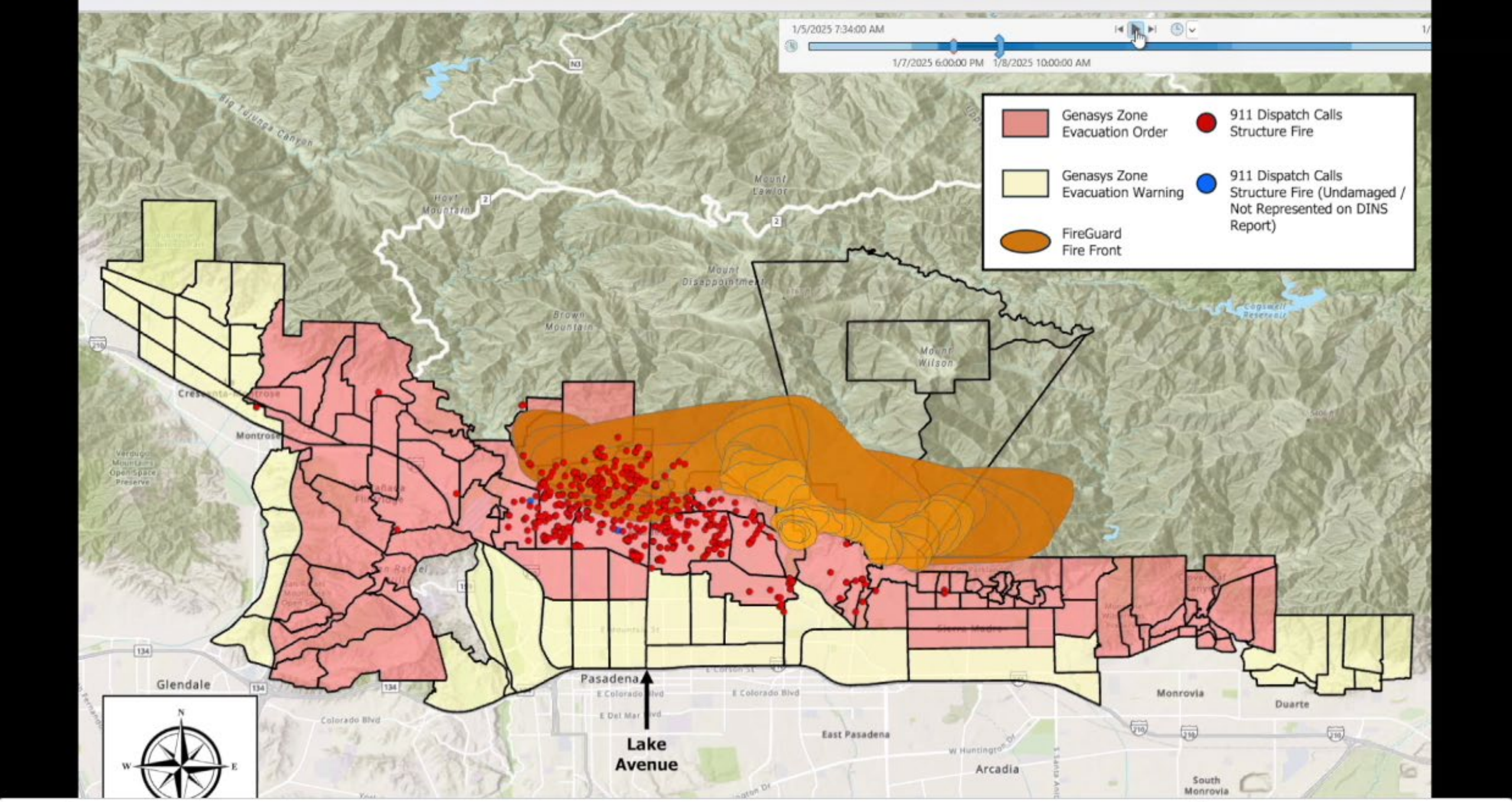
00:25.36


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 6:00:00 PM
1/8/2025 6:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone Evacuation Order
Genasys Zone Evacuation Warning
FireGuard Fire Front
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire (Undamaged / Not Represented on DINS Report)
Big Tujunga Canyon
Hoyt Mountain
Mount Lawlor
Mount Disappointment
Brown Mountain
Mount Wilson
Cogswell Reservoir
Crescenta-Montrose
Montrose
Verdugo Mountains Open Space Preserve
Glendale
Pasadena
Lake Avenue
East Pasadena
Arcadia
Monrovia
Duarte
South Monrovia
Colorado Blvd
E Colorado Blvd
N
W
E

00:27.46


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 6:00:00 PM
1/8/2025 8:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone Evacuation Order
Genasys Zone Evacuation Warning
FireGuard Fire Front
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire (Undamaged / Not Represented on DINS Report)
Big Tujunga Canyon
Mount Lawlor
Hoyt Mountain
Mount Disappointment
Brown Mountain
Mount Wilson
Cogswell Reservoir
Montrose
Verdugo Mountains Open Space Preserve
Glendale
Pasadena
Lake Avenue
East Pasadena
Arcadia
Monrovia
Duarte
South Monrovia
Colorado Blvd
E Colorado Blvd
E Del Mar Blvd
W Huntington Dr
N
W
E

00:32.52


1/5/2025 7:34:00 AM
1/7/2025 6:00:00 PM
1/8/2025 10:00:00 AM
Genasys Zone Evacuation Order
Genasys Zone Evacuation Warning
FireGuard Fire Front
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire
911 Dispatch Calls Structure Fire (Undamaged / Not Represented on DINS Report)
Big Tujunga Canyon
Hoyt Mountain
Mount Lawlor
Mount Disappointment
Brown Mountain
Mount Wilson
Cogswell Reservoir
Montrose
Verdugo Mountains Open Space Preserve
Glendale
Pasadena
Lake Avenue
East Pasadena
Arcadia
Monrovia
Duarte
South Monrovia
Colorado Blvd
N
W
E

00:38.20

Questions and Discussion

McChrystal Group

McChrystal Group makes it possible to optimize your organization **without compromising performance**. Forged in combat and proven across industries, we use our Team of Teams® framework to **transform how your people, processes, and technology work together** so you can optimize the organization on your terms.

Visit us at *www.mcchrystalgroup.com*.

© 2025 McChrystal Group, LLC. All rights reserved.